

Timeline Compression Trap Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 25-35 min

Category	History	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	timeline-compression-trap

Big idea: The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students build compressed timelines and see how scale choices make historical change appear sudden or gradual.

Student Prompt

Inspect Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Timeline Compression Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How do historical representations shape interpretation?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how the scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: How do historical representations shape interpretation?

Setup Checklist

- Use an event sequence with both long-term causes and sudden triggers.
- Give groups different physical lengths of timeline paper.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden.
- History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/timeline-compression-trap/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/timeline-compression-trap/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/timeline-compression-trap/visual-prompt.svg>
- Event cards with dates, descriptions, and category labels.
- Two timeline strips: compressed overview and expanded close-up.

Run Sequence

1. Give groups the same set of event cards.
2. One group uses a compressed timeline and another uses an expanded timeline.
3. Students place events and write a one-sentence interpretation of the process.
4. Groups compare whether change looks sudden, gradual, inevitable, or contested.
5. Debrief how representation affects historical knowledge.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: How do historical representations shape interpretation?
- Does changing scale change what counts as a cause?

- When does simplification become distortion?

Teacher Quick Script

- Your timeline is making an argument about pace and importance.
- What disappears when the scale changes?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...